

(Cover letter for Christian Webb letter, from Article 53 proponents)

The July 19, 2025 letter (below) from Dr Christian Webb raises concerns about the scale of buildings that can rise to 65 feet tall (5 story) in a predominantly 2.5-story residential neighborhood. The size of the proposed 126 Broadway building has impacts on traffic sight lines (affecting automobile, cyclist and pedestrian safety) and overall congestion. A four-story building creates shadow and restricts access to sunlight for abutters and pedestrians to begin with, and the impacts are greater when a building receives a fifth floor bonus. Further, these impacts are particularly acute when the project receives permission to build with a zero sidewalk setback only available to those projects that meet the commercial bonus requirements.

The letter (below) speaks to the tradeoff between burden and benefit and why the bonus rule was intended as a strict threshold. This is why the commercial use bonus was not intended to enable any lesser amount of commercial space to be used to satisfy the 60% ground floor threshold. Instead, developer bonuses were meant to bring the maximum intended BENEFIT of the bonus to those affected. To realize this intended benefit, the rules should be strictly enforced, and a full 60% of the ground floor 'footprint' allotted so that the neighbors - and the town - receive maximally viable commercial spaces, rather than token ones that do not honor the spirit of the rule's intention.

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From: Webb, Christian A.,PHD Sent: Saturday, July 19, 2025 7:17:12 PM
To: Claire Ricker Cc: Renata Cardoso Subject:
RE: Docket #3862 - 126 Broadway Site Plan Review

Dear Chair Zsemsbery and Members of the Arlington Redevelopment Board,
I am writing to express my concerns regarding the proposed mixed-use development at 126 Broadway (Docket #3862). As a longtime Arlington resident who values our community's character and livability, I respectfully request that the Board carefully consider the following issues.

The proposed 5-story, 50-foot building represents a dramatic departure from the established residential character of this neighborhood. The current two-family home fits harmoniously within the existing streetscape of primarily 1-3 story residential buildings. This massive structure would tower over neighboring homes, fundamentally altering the intimate, family-friendly atmosphere that defines this area.

The building's bulk and massing, despite architectural attempts at modulation, remains incompatible with the human scale that makes our neighborhood walkable and welcoming to families with children.

Broadway already experiences significant traffic congestion, particularly during peak commuting hours. Adding 14 residential units plus a commercial space will substantially increase vehicle trips, pedestrian activity, and delivery traffic at this corner location. This is compounded by the

fact that a multi-story building was recently constructed directly across the street at the same Broadway/Everett intersection, already increasing traffic in this area.

Of particular concern:

- **Child Safety:** This intersection is heavily used by children walking to and from Thompson School on Everett St. Our neighborhood has many families with young children who walk, bike, and play in the area. The Broadway/Everett corner is a key crossing point for school children, and increased traffic density from this large development poses significant safety risks that have not been adequately addressed in the application materials.
- **Parking Pressure:** While 18 garage spaces are proposed, realistic parking demand will likely exceed this supply, pushing additional vehicles onto already crowded neighborhood streets.
- **Corner Location:** The Broadway/Everett Street intersection will see increased turning movements and potential sight line issues with a building of this scale, particularly dangerous given the school foot traffic.
- **The commercial space at the bottom** could exacerbate the above issues regarding traffic and parking spots.
- **Shadow and Light:** The shadow studies show significant impacts on neighboring properties (including our house at 100 Everett st, which is immediately next door).

I want to bring to the Board's attention that many residents in this immediate area have only recently become aware of this significant proposal. Since learning of the project, several neighbors

have spontaneously approached me expressing serious concerns about this large construction that would dramatically change our neighborhood character.

There also appears to be confusion among residents about the hearing schedule - whether the primary hearing is July 21st or the continued hearing on August 11th. As more neighbors become

aware of this proposal, I expect you will receive additional correspondence expressing similar concerns. The scale of this project and its potential impacts warrant ensuring that the affected community has adequate opportunity to provide input.

Given the significant scale of this proposal and its potential impacts, I respectfully request:

1. Extended community input sessions to ensure all affected residents have opportunity to comment
2. Stronger conditions addressing parking, delivery schedules, and construction impacts
3. Consideration of reduced scale alternatives that better respect neighborhood character
4. Clear communication about hearing dates and continuation procedures to ensure proper community notification

While I support thoughtful development that meets housing needs, this proposal goes too far in prioritizing density over community character and quality of life. Arlington's strength lies in its diverse, livable neighborhoods, and we must be careful not to sacrifice what makes our community

special in the pursuit of maximum development.

I trust the Board will carefully weigh these concerns and work with the applicant to develop a more

appropriate proposal that respects both housing goals and neighborhood livability.

Thank you for your consideration and service to our community.

Could you kindly confirm receipt?

Respectfully submitted,

Christian

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